IT Support Interview Preparation

10 common questions with strong, structured answers

Q1. A user says their internet is slow. How do you troubleshoot?

A: Start by scoping the problem: is it one user, one site, or the whole office? Check Wi-Fi signal strength and whether they're on 2.4 GHz vs 5 GHz. Run a wired speed test against the gateway, then an external test (e.g. speedtest.net) to isolate LAN vs ISP. Inspect router/switch utilisation, look for bandwidth-heavy apps (backups, OneDrive sync, streaming), check for duplex mismatches, and review DNS response times. If only one user, restart the NIC, update drivers, and check for malware. Escalate to the ISP with logs if the WAN link is the bottleneck.

Q2. A user can't log in to their workstation. Walk me through your steps.

A: Confirm what "can't log in" means - wrong password, account locked, or no domain connection. Verify Caps Lock and the correct username/domain. Check Active Directory for a locked or disabled account and password expiry. Confirm the workstation can reach a domain controller (ping, nltest). Try a known-good account on the same machine to isolate user vs device. If it's the device, check time sync (Kerberos fails if clock skew >5 min) and the secure channel (netdom). Document the root cause and reset securely.

Q3. The printer isn't working. How do you approach it?

A: Ask whether it's one user or everyone, and whether the printer is local, network, or print-server hosted. Check the printer's physical state: power, paper, toner, error display. Ping the printer IP. On the workstation, clear the print queue and restart the Print Spooler service. Reinstall the driver if jobs fail silently. For print servers, verify the share, permissions, and that the spooler service is healthy. Document and consider a driver standardisation if recurring.

Q4. Explain the difference between TCP and UDP and when you'd use each.

A: TCP is connection-oriented, reliable, and ordered - it uses a three-way handshake, acknowledgements, and retransmission. Use it where data integrity matters: web (HTTP/HTTPS), email, file transfer. UDP is connectionless and best-effort - lower overhead, no guaranteed delivery. Use it for latency-sensitive or broadcast traffic: DNS queries, VoIP, video streaming, gaming, DHCP.

Q5. A user reports a suspicious email. What do you do?

A: Don't click anything. Ask the user not to interact with links or attachments and to forward the email as an attachment to the security mailbox. Inspect headers for SPF/DKIM/DMARC failures and check the sender domain for look-alikes. Detonate links in a sandbox or URL scanner. If malicious, quarantine the message tenant-wide, block the sender and any IOCs, reset credentials if the user clicked, and run an endpoint scan. Log the incident and brief the user - awareness is part of the fix. Under POPIA, assess whether a notifiable breach occurred.

Q6. What's the difference between a hub, a switch, and a router?

A: A hub is a Layer 1 device that repeats every packet to every port - obsolete, causes collisions. A switch is Layer 2, forwards frames using MAC addresses, and creates separate collision domains per port. A router is Layer 3, forwards packets between different networks using IP addresses and routing tables, and is what connects your LAN to the internet.

Q7. How do you handle a ticket from a frustrated, non-technical user?

A: Lead with empathy: acknowledge the impact, not just the issue. Listen fully before diagnosing, then mirror the problem back in plain language so they feel heard. Set expectations on next steps and ETA. Avoid jargon - say "let's restart the program" not "let's kill the process." Keep them updated even when there's no progress. Close the loop by explaining what was wrong and how to spot it next time and log the resolution for the knowledge base.

Q8. Describe the difference between authentication and authorisation.

A: Authentication proves who you are - passwords, MFA tokens, biometrics, certificates. Authorisation decides what you're allowed to do once authenticated - file permissions, RBAC group membership, application roles. You can be authenticated but not authorised. Good practice pairs strong authentication (MFA) with least-privilege authorisation.

Q9. A laptop is running very slowly. How do you investigate?

A: Gather context: when did it start, after an update, all apps or just one? Open Task Manager / Activity Monitor and check CPU, memory, disk, and network usage - high disk on a spinning drive is a classic culprit. Look for runaway processes, pending Windows updates, low free disk space, or malware. Check startup programs, browser extensions, and antivirus scan activity. Verify the device meets the OS's requirements; recommend an SSD or RAM upgrade if it's genuinely under-spec. Document findings before reimaging.

Q10. How would you secure a small office network of about 25 users?

A: Start with the basics that prevent 90% of incidents: a business-grade firewall with default-deny inbound, segmented VLANs (staff, guest, servers, IoT), WPA3 Wi-Fi with a separate guest SSID, and disabled WPS. Enforce MFA on all cloud accounts, least-privilege through Active Directory groups, and patch management for OS, browsers, and firmware. Deploy endpoint protection with EDR, centralised logging, and daily off-site backups tested by restore. Write a short POPIA-aligned acceptable-use and incident-response policy, run quarterly phishing simulations, and review access whenever someone change's role or leaves.